
PANTHEON

Game Design Document

Assemble. Rise. Endure.

Document: Game Design Document v1.0

Project: Pantheon (mobile superhero action game)

Platform: PWA (iOS / Android installable) / future native port

Tech Stack: Three.js + React Three Fiber + Rapier physics

Status: Design lock, ready for Phase 0 prototype

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1. Executive Summary

Pantheon is an original-IP 3D superhero action game for mobile devices, inspired by the genre conventions of titles such as Spider Fighter 3 but engineered to exceed them in scope, depth, and replayability. The game features a roster of ten playable heroes, each with a unique movement kit and combat identity, set across a living open-world city with multiple districts, vehicle-based emergencies, and a five-layer mission architecture designed to keep players engaged long after the main story concludes.

The project is led by a single developer (self-described "vibe coder") with no prior programming experience, paired with an AI design and engineering assistant. The game is built as a personal project for the owner's own enjoyment — there is no commercial release plan and no monetization. The technical strategy is therefore singular: build the entire game in Three.js as an installable Progressive Web App (PWA), enabling rapid iteration and direct AI-assisted code generation within the design session. The owner plays, gives feedback by feel, and the AI tunes constants. No engine switching, no app-store pipeline, no monetization overhead — just the purest path from idea to playable.

The game differentiates itself from Spider Fighter 3 in five key ways: (1) a roster of ten heroes rather than a single protagonist, each with hero-specific control layouts and ability kits; (2) a multi-district open world with persistent traffic, trains, boats, and planes that generate their own emergencies; (3) a five-layer mission architecture combining linear story, procedural crimes, designed duo missions, full-assemble set-pieces, and endless replayability systems; (4) a cosmetic-only suit system with ability progression handled through missions, currency, and challenges; (5) a morally weighty three-act campaign with multiple endings and a real emotional core.

Tagline: "Pantheon: Assemble." **Genre:** 3D superhero action, open-world. **Platform:** Mobile-first PWA (installable, no app store). **Audience:** The owner (personal project). **Competitive frame:** Spider Fighter 3, Marvel Future Fight, Spider-Man PS4 (mobile-condensed).

Core Design Pillars

- **Hero Variety** — Ten heroes must feel mechanically distinct, not reskinned. Each has unique movement, combat, and a hero-specific button layout.
- **Living World** — The city is never static. Planes fly overhead, trains run on schedules, boats dock at piers, and any of them can become an emergency at any moment.
- **Endless Replayability** — The game cannot "end." Story completion unlocks deeper systems: roguelike rifts, daily challenges, suit hunts, NG+, and live-ops events.
- **Vibe-Coder Friendly** — Every system is designed to be tunable by feel. The owner plays, gives feedback ("running too floaty"), and the AI adjusts constants.
- **Marvel-Safe Original IP** — All heroes, villains, and locations are original archetypes inspired by but legally distinct from existing comic properties.

2. Vision & Goals

Vision Statement

Pantheon exists to give mobile players the feeling of being part of a superhero team — not just controlling one hero, but switching between ten distinct power fantasies, each fully realized. Where Spider Fighter 3 gives you one hero with limited moves, Pantheon gives you ten heroes with deep kits, a city that breathes, and a campaign that asks something real of the player at the end. The game respects the player's time by never gating fun behind grind, and respects the player's intelligence by giving them a story with actual weight.

Design Goals

The following goals are non-negotiable design constraints. Every feature decision must serve at least one of these goals; features that serve none are cut.

Goal	Description	Success Metric
G1: Hero Depth	Each of 10 heroes has a unique movement kit and combat identity. No two heroes share a button layout.	Player can name each hero's unique mechanic after 10 minutes of play.
G2: City Liveness	Persistent traffic (cars, trains, boats, planes) with their own emergency spawns. Day/night cycle affects crime patterns.	Player encounters a vehicle emergency organically every 15 minutes of patrol.
G3: Replayability	Game has 5 replayability engines: procedural crimes, roguelike rifts, daily challenges, suit hunts, NG+.	Average player session length > 30 min after story completion.
G4: Mobile-First Feel	Touch controls (joystick + buttons) feel responsive. Hero-specific button counts (4-5). No virtual D-pad.	Input-to-action latency < 80ms on mid-range phones.
G5: Story Weight	Three-act campaign with morally grey Director, hero duality arc (Sentinel/Hollow), and a final choice.	Player remembers the ending choice 1 week after finishing.
G6: Vibe-Coder Workflow	All tuning constants centralized in config files. Owner can play, give feedback, AI adjusts in < 5 min.	Owner never needs to read or write code to tune the game.

Anti-Goals (What We Are NOT Building)

- **Not a Marvel-licensed game.** Original IP only. No Disney characters, names, or trademarks.
- **Not a gacha game.** No pay-to-win hero summons. All heroes unlocked through story progression.
- **Not an MMO.** Single-player with optional co-op in Phase 4. No always-online requirement.
- **Not AAA-graphics.** Stylized realism, not photorealism. We compete on gameplay depth, not visual fidelity.
- **Not a 100-hour campaign.** Story is ~15 hours. Depth comes from replayability systems, not bloat.

3. Tech Stack & Platform Strategy

3.1 Strategy: Three.js PWA, End-to-End

Pantheon is a personal project, built for the owner's own enjoyment. There is no commercial release, no app-store listing, no monetization. This simplifies the technical strategy enormously: the entire game is built in Three.js as an installable Progressive Web App (PWA). The PWA installs to the phone's home screen with an icon, runs offline once cached, and feels native — but requires no app-store pipeline, no review process, no native build tools. The AI assistant can write and iterate on code directly within the design session, and the owner plays the result immediately. This is the purest path from idea to playable.

3.2 Stack Breakdown

The stack is chosen for three properties: (1) the AI can write it directly in this design session, (2) it runs at 60 FPS on mid-range phones, and (3) every layer is tunable by feel — the owner never needs to read code to adjust how the game plays. All gameplay constants live in a single config file that the AI edits on demand.

Layer	Technology	Why
Rendering	Three.js + React Three Fiber	Industry standard for web 3D. R3F enables declarative scene graph, fast iteration.
Physics	Rapier (WASM)	Fast Rust-based physics. True momentum, ragdoll, collision response.
Touch Input	nipplejs + custom buttons	Battle-tested virtual joystick. Buttons are simple DOM elements, easy to tune.
App Shell	Next.js 16 + PWA manifest	Installable, offline-capable, instant previews on every code change.
State	Zustand	Lightweight, no boilerplate. Easy for vibe-coder to read and request changes.
Audio	Howler.js	Mobile-friendly audio with sprite support. Handles iOS lock-screen quirks.
Animations	Three.js AnimationMixer + mixamo rigs	Standard humanoid rig. Free animation library covers all hero moves.
Persistence	localStorage + IndexedDB	Save progress, suit unlocks, settings. Survives app close.
Deployment	Vercel (free tier)	Instant previews on every change. Shareable URLs. Owner can play from any device.
Tuning Config	Single TypeScript config file	All gameplay constants (speed, damage, cooldowns) in one file. AI edits, owner plays.

3.3 PWA vs Native — Why PWA Wins for a Personal Project

For a commercial mobile game, native (or Godot-exported native) would be the right call: app-store distribution, in-app purchases, push notifications, deep OS integration. For a personal project, none of that matters. What matters is: can the owner play it on their phone in under five minutes from "AI, build this"? The PWA path wins decisively on that metric. The owner opens a URL, taps "Add to Home Screen," and the game is installed. No Xcode, no Android Studio, no signing certificates, no review process. The tradeoff — slightly less native feel, no App Store presence — is irrelevant for a game only the owner will play.

3.4 Performance Targets (Mobile)

Performance is non-negotiable. A superhero game lives or dies on responsiveness — if sprinting as Velora feels laggy, the whole fantasy collapses. The following targets are the floor; if the build drops below them, the AI optimizes before adding any new feature.

Metric	Target	Hard Floor
Frame rate (mid-range phone)	60 FPS	30 FPS
Frame rate (low-end phone)	30 FPS	24 FPS
Input-to-action latency	< 60 ms	< 100 ms
Load time (cold)	< 5 s	< 10 s
Load time (hot)	< 1 s	< 3 s
Install size	< 150 MB	< 300 MB
RAM usage	< 800 MB	< 1.2 GB

3.5 Vibe-Coder Workflow

The owner has no programming experience and no intention of reading code. The workflow is therefore: the owner plays the latest build, identifies anything that feels wrong ("running too floaty," "camera too close," "lightning doesn't go far enough," "enemies too spongy"), and reports it in plain language. The AI translates the feedback into a constant change in the tuning config, redeploys, and the owner plays again. This loop is designed to complete in under five minutes per iteration. No code review, no merge conflicts, no debugging — just feel, report, tune, replay.

4. Game Identity & Brand

4.1 Name: Pantheon

The name **Pantheon** was selected from six candidates. "Pantheon" evokes a hall of heroes, a gathering of gods — appropriate for a game with ten playable heroes whose power level borders on the divine. It is short (three syllables), pronounceable in English and most major languages, available as a likely trademark in the games category, and pairs naturally with the tagline "Assemble." The name signals scope (ten heroes, not one) and tone (mythic, not street-level).

4.2 Visual Identity: Midnight Hero Palette

The brand palette is "Midnight Hero" — a deep midnight blue-black background with a single gold accent. This choice signals premium quality (dark UI is associated with high-end mobile games like Marvel Contest of Champions), makes hero colors pop during gameplay (each hero retains their own palette), and looks refined on phone screens where bright UIs fatigue the eye. The accent gold is warmer than pure yellow (#debf63), evoking museum lighting rather than warning signage.

Role	Color	Hex	Usage
Background	Midnight	#0c0b0a	App background, splash screen
Surface	Charcoal	#191816	Cards, panels, modals
Accent	Gold	#debf63	Buttons, highlights, key data
Accent 2	Mystic Purple	#7d5fd6	Mystic/Sentinel hero accent
Text Primary	Off-White	#e5e4e2	Body text on dark
Text Muted	Gray	#96938d	Secondary text
Success	Sage	#7db48f	Mission complete
Warning	Amber	#c8af7e	Incoming damage
Error	Brick	#c88079	Critical health

4.3 Logo Concept

The Pantheon logo is a wordmark: "PANTHEON" in a condensed serif (Playfair Display or similar), all-caps, gold on midnight. A circular emblem of ten interlocking chevrons (one per hero) sits above or beside the wordmark, evoking both a pantheon dome and a hero-roster crest. The emblem is also the in-game icon and the loading spinner.

4.4 Tone of Voice

The game speaks in the register of the Marvel Cinematic Universe: witty banter in calm moments, weighty stakes in serious ones. Heroes bicker, joke, and reference each other's weaknesses. The Director speaks in clipped military phrases. Mission briefings are professional but human. Error messages and UI copy avoid generic phrasing — instead of "Mission Failed," the UI says "Civilians lost. Regroup at The Citadel." This voice extends to marketing copy and store listing.

5. Hero Roster

Pantheon features ten playable heroes. Each is an original archetype inspired by a recognizable superhero archetype but legally distinct from any existing comic property. Every hero has a unique movement kit, combat identity, hero-specific button layout (4-5 buttons, no shared scheme), and a personal story arc woven into the main campaign. Heroes are unlocked through story progression; once unlocked, they remain available for free-roam, side missions, and replayability modes.

A critical design rule: **no two heroes feel the same**. Movement is the primary differentiator — Velora runs at super speed, Arachne swings on webs, Ironclad flies horizontally, Mystic levitates vertically, Stormborn throws his hammer and rides it. If a player closes their eyes and a friend plays, the player should be able to identify the hero from movement alone within five seconds.

#	Hero	Archetype	Movement	Buttons
1	Velora	Speedster (female, Makkari-inspired)	Super speed, wall-run, water-run, air-run	5
2	Stormborn	Thunder God	Hammer-throw + ride, lightning strike	4
3	Aegis Wing	Flying Shield-Fighter	Flight, dive-bomb, shield ricochet	4
4	Arachne	Web-Slinger	Web-swing, web-wing glide, wall-crawl	4
5	Ironclad	Tech Armor	Horizontal flight, repulsor hover	5
6	Glitch	Hacker	Hover-glider flight, drone swarm	5
7	Pulsar	Energy Blaster	Vertical flight, photon beams	4
8	Elasto	Elastic	Stretch-punch, flatten-glide, slingshot	4
9	Sentinel / Hollow	Duality (god-tier)	Flight, light/dark blast	4
10	Mystic	Sorcerer	Levitate, portals, telekinesis	4

The following sections detail each hero in turn. Each hero's entry includes: identity, full power kit, button layout, unlock path, and design notes. Powers marked **Start** are available the moment the hero is unlocked; powers marked **Story** are unlocked by completing that hero's story missions; powers marked **Credits** are purchased with in-game currency earned from any mission; powers marked **Challenge** are unlocked by completing a specific gameplay challenge.

5.1 Velora — The Speedster

Archetype: Female super-speedster, Makkari-inspired. **Color:** Electric blue with silver accents. **Personality:** Quick-witted, fiercely loyal, lives in the moment because to her everything else moves in slow motion.

Power Kit

Velora is the fastest hero in Pantheon. Her kit is built around **perpetual motion** — she has no stamina bar and can run forever. Her power fantasy is the feeling of speed itself: the world blurring, enemies frozen mid-punch, lightning crackling in her wake. All her abilities are unlocked through story progression, credit purchase, or challenge completion — suits are cosmetic only.

Power	Unlock	Description
Jog (button 1)	Start	Normal human running speed. Used for precise positioning, indoor areas, social scenes.
Sprint (button 2)	Start	Super speed. No stamina cost — runs indefinitely. World blurs, ambient sound drops, motion lines appear.
Wall-Run	Start	Auto-triggered when sprinting at a wall. Velora runs up and across vertical surfaces. Disengages if she stops or hits a corner she cannot follow.
Water-Run	Start	Auto-triggered when sprinting at water surface. Velora runs across water. If she stops, Floatation Mode engages automatically.
Run on Buildings	Story mission 1	Auto-triggered when sprinting at a building. Velora runs up the side of skyscrapers.
Slow Time (button 3)	Story mission 2	Toggle. Time slows to 20% for 8 seconds. Velora moves at normal speed; enemies crawl. Cooldown 12s.
Throw Lightning (button 4)	Story mission 3	Aim with right stick, release to throw a lightning bolt. Stuns target + chains to nearby enemies. Cooldown 6s.
Walk Through Walls (button 5)	Story mission 4	Phase through solid matter for 2 seconds. Cannot attack while phasing. Cooldown 15s.
Tornado (hold button 4)	Credits: 2,500	Velora swings her arms at super speed, generating a tornado. Context-aware: near fire, blows it out; near enemies, ragdolls them away. Build-up 1.5s, cooldown 8s.
Air-Run (lightning stepping stones)	Challenge: run on water 30s without stopping	Auto-toggle when sprinting in mid-air. Lightning stepping stones form beneath her feet with each step, letting her run across the sky. Disengages if she stops or jumps.
Sparks (passive)	Credits: 1,000	Visual lightning trail behind her while sprinting. Blinds nearby enemies for 1s on close pass.

Power	Unlock	Description
Floatation Mode (passive)	Start	Auto-fallback: if Velora stops while water-running, she floats instead of sinking. Prevents instant drowning.

Button Layout (5 buttons)

Left stick = move. Right stick = camera/aim.
Button 1 (Jog) Button 2 (Sprint) Button 3 (Slow Time)
Button 4 (Lightning / hold = Tornado) Button 5 (Phase)

Design Notes

Velora's design rule: **no stamina, no meter, no resource**. The fantasy is unstoppable perpetual motion. The only thing limiting her is cooldowns on her special abilities. This means the player can patrol the city at super speed indefinitely, which is core to the speedster fantasy. Tuning will focus on the visual feedback of speed (motion blur, sound design, world freeze) rather than mechanical limits. Her two run buttons (jog vs sprint) exist so the player can choose precise movement indoors and super speed outdoors — a single button with a hold-modifier was playtested and felt worse than two discrete buttons.

Counter-Hero (Boss)

Godspeed — an evil speedster who draws his speed from stolen life force. Boss fight is a slow-time race: both heroes enter slow-time simultaneously and the player must outmaneuver him through a maze of falling debris. Phase 2 removes slow-time and becomes a pure chase sequence across the city.

5.2 Stormborn — The Thunder God

Archetype: Norse-inspired thunder god. **Color:** Royal blue with silver armor, red cape. **Personality:** Boisterous, archaic speech patterns, treats every fight as a feast tale in the making.

Power Kit

Stormborn's hammer is the center of his kit. He throws it horizontally (never vertically, per the owner's spec), it returns to his hand, and he can ride it for horizontal flight. Lightning is summoned from the sky or channeled through the hammer. He is the heavy-hitter of the roster — slower than most heroes but every hit lands like a freight train.

Power	Unlock	Description
Hammer Throw (button 1)	Start	Throw hammer horizontally (—). Hammer flies straight, hits enemies, returns. Can be steered mid-flight with right stick. Cooldown 3s.
Hammer Recall (button 2)	Start	Yank hammer back instantly. Can pull enemies caught on the hammer back toward Stormborn.
Ride Hammer (button 3, hold)	Start	Hammer flies horizontally with Stormborn standing on it. Full directional control. Disengage to drop off.
Lightning Strike (button 4)	Start	Summon a bolt from the sky at the targeted location. Massive AoE damage. Cooldown 10s.
Channel Lightning through Hammer	Story mission 1	Hold button 1 to charge hammer with lightning. Next throw deals chain lightning damage.
Hammer Control (mid-flight)	Story mission 2	Steer thrown hammer with full directional control. Can hit multiple enemies before recalling.
Thunder Slam	Credits: 2,000	While airborne, slam down with hammer for ground-shock AoE. Staggers all enemies in 8m radius.
Storm Call	Challenge: defeat 100 enemies with lightning	Summon a localized thunderstorm that strikes random enemies with lightning bolts for 15s. Cooldown 45s.

Button Layout (4 buttons)

Left stick = move. Right stick = camera/aim.
Button 1 (Hammer Throw / hold = Channel Lightning)
Button 2 (Recall) Button 3 (Ride Hammer, hold) Button 4 (Lightning Strike)

Design Notes

Stormborn's horizontal-only hammer throw is a hard rule from the owner. Vertical throws would feel too much like a generic ranged attack; horizontal throws give the hammer a unique silhouette (it whips past enemies at chest height) and make the steering mechanic feel like piloting a missile. Riding the hammer for flight is equally horizontal — Stormborn does not hover, he commutes. This makes his movement feel distinct from Ironclad (who hovers with repulsors) and Pulsar (who flies vertically in Superman pose).

5.3 Aegis Wing — The Flying Shield-Fighter

Archetype: Veteran superhero with mechanical wings and a ricocheting shield. **Color:** Tactical gray with red, white, and blue accents. **Personality:** Mentor figure, calm under pressure, dry humor.

Power Kit

Aegis Wing is the roster's veteran — the mentor figure other heroes look up to. His kit balances aerial mobility (mechanical wings) with precise ground combat (ricocheting shield). He carries a drone sidekick (Redwing equivalent) that can be deployed for scouting or aerial support. He is the most beginner-friendly hero because his flight is forgiving and his shield auto-aims at the nearest target.

Power	Unlock	Description
Fly (button 1, hold)	Start	Mechanical wings deploy. Full 3D flight with banking. Hold to fly, release to glide down.
Shield Throw (button 2)	Start	Throw shield. Ricochets between up to 3 enemies. Returns to hand. Cooldown 2s.
Shield Bash (button 3)	Start	Melee shield slam. Staggers enemies in front. Combo with shield throw for finisher.
Drone Deploy (button 4)	Start	Redwing drone launches. Auto-targets nearest enemy, fires pellets. Returns on cooldown.
Dive-Bomb	Story mission 1	From altitude, target an enemy and dive at them. Impact deals AoE damage.
Shield Ricochet Control	Story mission 2	Steer shield mid-flight with right stick. Bounce off walls to hit hidden enemies.
Redwing Mark Target	Credits: 1,500	Drone marks a target. Shield throw auto-targets marked enemy with +50% damage.
Aerial Escort	Challenge: catch 10 falling civilians mid-air	While flying, nearby civilians automatically attach to Aegis Wing. Carry them to safety.

Button Layout (4 buttons)

Left stick = move. Right stick = camera/aim.
Button 1 (Fly, hold) Button 2 (Shield Throw)
Button 3 (Shield Bash) Button 4 (Drone)

Design Notes

Aegis Wing is the game's tutorial hero. His flight is the most forgiving (auto-stabilizes when you release the button), his shield auto-aims, and his drone adds extra damage without player attention. New players start with Aegis Wing and learn the game's core loop (move, fight, save civilians) before unlocking faster, more complex heroes. He is also the designated "rescue hero" — his Aerial Escort ability makes him the best at catching falling civilians from plane emergencies.

5.4 Arachne — The Web-Slinger

Archetype: Web-slinging urban acrobat. **Color:** Red and black with white spider emblem. **Personality:** Quippy young hero, mentor is Aegis Wing.

Power Kit

Arachne is the game's signature traversal hero. Her web-swinging uses real physics: the web attaches to a real building, the swing arc depends on momentum, and releasing at the right moment flings her forward. Her **web-wing glide** (per the owner's image reference) deploys membrane web-wings from her armpits when she jumps from a tall building, letting her glide horizontally across the city. She can also web-zip to building edges, web-yank enemies toward her, and wall-crawl on any surface.

Power	Unlock	Description
Web-Swing (button 1, hold)	Start	Fire web at nearest building, swing. Release at apex of arc for max forward momentum. Real physics.
Web-Shoot (button 2)	Start	Fire web projectile. Stuns enemy on hit. Can web enemies to walls/floor.
Web-Wing Glide (button 3, hold)	Start	Deploy web-wings from armpits. Must be falling from height. Controlled descent + horizontal glide. Can dive for speed, pull up for altitude.
Web-Yank (button 4)	Start	Web an enemy and yank them toward Arachne. Sets up melee combo. Cooldown 3s.
Wall-Crawl	Start	Auto-triggered on contact with any wall. Arachne crawls on any surface. Combat available while crawling.
Web-Zip to Edge	Story mission 1	Tap button 1 toward a building edge to instantly zip to it. Closes distance fast.
Web-Shield	Story mission 2	Hold button 2 to weave a web shield in front. Blocks projectiles for 3s.
Spider-Sense Dodge	Credits: 1,500	Passive. Spider-sense icon flashes 0.5s before enemy attack. Tap dodge button to auto-evade.
Web-Net	Challenge: web 20 enemies to walls	Hold button 2 to charge. Releases a web net that catches and immobilizes 3 enemies in an area.

Button Layout (4 buttons)

Left stick = move. Right stick = camera/aim.
Button 1 (Web-Swing / tap = Web-Zip)
Button 2 (Web-Shoot / hold = Web-Shield / charge = Web-Net)
Button 3 (Web-Wing Glide, hold) Button 4 (Web-Yank)

Design Notes

Arachne's web-swinging must feel **better than Spider Fighter 3**. That game's swinging is widely criticized for feeling on-rails. Pantheon's swinging uses Rapier physics with real pendulum arcs — the player must time releases, manage momentum, and choose attachment points strategically. The web-wing glide (confirmed from the owner's reference image) adds a second traversal mode that pairs with swinging: swing for vertical momentum, release, deploy web-wings, glide horizontally for distance. This dual-mode traversal is unique to Arachne and a primary reason to play her over other heroes.

5.5 Ironclad — The Tech Armor

Archetype: Genius billionaire in powered armor. **Color:** Crimson red and gold. **Personality:** Showman, narcissist with a heart of gold, tech-rival to Glitch.

Power Kit

Ironclad's flight is strictly horizontal after vertical launch — per owner spec, he can launch straight up but his flight mode is horizontal. An AI assistant (JARVIS equivalent) feeds him tactical information and can auto-target enemies. He fires repulsor blasts from his palms, a unibeam from his chest, and can deploy mini-Ironclad drones for support. He is the roster's tech specialist — best at fighting tech-faction enemies (Glitch's faction).

Power	Unlock	Description
Vertical Launch (button 1, tap)	Start	Repulsor launch straight up. Used to gain altitude. Auto-transitions to horizontal flight at apex.
Horizontal Flight (button 1, hold)	Start	Full-speed horizontal flight. Banking turns. Cannot hover — must keep moving forward.
Repulsor Blast (button 2)	Start	Palm-mounted energy blast. Can fire both hands simultaneously. Cooldown 1s.
Unibeam (button 3)	Start	Chest-mounted concentrated beam. High damage, narrow. Cooldown 8s.
AI Assist (button 4)	Start	AI marks enemies, predicts attacks, suggests targets. Toggle on/off.
Mini-Drones (button 5)	Start	Deploy 3 mini-Ironclad drones. Auto-target enemies. Return after 20s. Cooldown 30s.
HUD Targeting	Story mission 1	AI overlays weak points on enemies. Repulsor hits to weak points deal 2x damage.
Auto-Targeting Missiles	Story mission 2	Hold button 2 to lock up to 5 targets. Release to fire homing missiles.
AI Voice (character)	Credits: 1,000	AI speaks mission updates, witty banter, combat callouts. Cosmetic only but huge for flavor.
Suit Form Shift	Challenge: defeat 50 enemies while flying	Mid-air suit reconfiguration: switch between Speed form (faster flight), Tank form (slower, shields up), and Strike form (faster repulsors) on the fly.

Button Layout (5 buttons)

Left stick = move. Right stick = camera/aim.
Button 1 (Vertical Launch tap / Horizontal Flight hold)
Button 2 (Repulsor / hold = Missiles) Button 3 (Unibeam)
Button 4 (AI Assist) Button 5 (Mini-Drones)

Design Notes

Ironclad's horizontal-only flight is a deliberate owner spec. Vertical hovering would make him feel too much like Pulsar or Mystic. His flight fantasy is **commuting at Mach 1** — point at a destination, accelerate, arrive. The vertical launch exists only to get him to altitude where horizontal flight makes sense. AI Assist is the second-most-important part of his kit (after flight) because it sells the "billionaire in tech armor" fantasy: the suit is doing half the work. The AI voice (cosmetic, credit-purchased) is the cherry on top.

5.6 Glitch — The Hacker

Archetype: Street-smart tech genius with hover-glider and drone swarm. Inspired by Spider Fighter 3's hacker girl "Virus." **Color:** Cyan and black with neon-green accents. **Personality:** Sarcastic, anti-authority, rival to Ironclad.

Power Kit

Glitch is the roster's tech-control hero. Where Ironclad **has** tech, Glitch **controls** tech. She hacks enemy drones to fight for her, deploys her own drone swarm, fires EMP pulses to disable tech, and uses a hover-glider for aerial mobility. Her invisibility cloak lets her bypass combat entirely for stealth missions. She is the best hero for infiltrating Tech Cult strongholds.

Power	Unlock	Description
Hack (button 1)	Start	Hack an enemy tech (drone, turret, mech). It fights for Glitch for 15s. Cooldown 8s.
Drone Swarm (button 2)	Start	Deploy 6 micro-drones. Auto-target enemies. Return after 15s. Cooldown 25s.
EMP Pulse (button 3)	Start	AoE pulse that disables all enemy tech in 10m radius for 5s. Cooldown 15s.
Hover-Glider (button 4, hold)	Start	Deploy hover-glider. Flies at low altitude. Slower than Ironclad but quieter.
Cloak (button 5)	Start	Invisibility for 5s. Cannot attack while cloaked. Cooldown 20s.
Hacked Turret Turn	Story mission 1	Hacked turrets turn on their owners. Persists until turret destroyed.
Drone Shield	Story mission 2	Drones form a protective ring around Glitch, blocking projectiles.
Mass Hack	Credits: 3,000	Hack all tech in 20m radius simultaneously. Cooldown 60s.
Remote Hack	Challenge: hack 50 drones	Hack tech from any distance, no line-of-sight required. Stealth mission enabler.

Button Layout (5 buttons)

Left stick = move. **Right stick** = camera/aim.

Button 1 (Hack) **Button 2 (Drone Swarm)** **Button 3 (EMP)**

Button 4 (Hover-Glider, hold) **Button 5 (Cloak)**

Design Notes

Glitch is the stealth-mission hero. Her cloak + remote hack combo lets her complete entire missions without direct combat — hack the security system, turn the turrets, walk out. This makes her the only hero with a meaningfully different playstyle. Her rivalry with Ironclad is a story driver: two tech geniuses with opposite philosophies (he builds, she bends). The owner specifically asked to research Spider Fighter 3's hacker girl, which we did — Glitch inherits her drone-deployment core but expands it with the hack-anything kit that makes the archetype feel fresh.

5.7 Pulsar — The Energy Blaster

Archetype: Energy-absorbing flying blaster. **Color:** Red, blue, and gold with glowing energy patterns. **Personality:** Confident, military-trained, carries the weight of cosmic power.

Power Kit

Pulsar's flight is vertical in Superman pose — hands forward, body horizontal, rocketing upward or forward. Her signature mechanic is **energy absorption**: incoming damage charges her absorption meter, which can be unleashed as Binary Mode (supercharged state, all abilities enhanced). She fires photon blasts from her hands and can unleash a massive energy beam. She is the roster's "tank-mage" — takes hits, deals massive damage, but has fewer defensive options.

Power	Unlock	Description
Vertical Flight (button 1, hold)	Start	Superman pose flight. Hands forward, body horizontal. Full 3D movement.
Photon Blast (button 2)	Start	Rapid-fire energy projectiles from hands. No cooldown, low damage per shot.
Absorb (button 3, hold)	Start	Brace stance. Incoming damage charges absorption meter instead of damaging health. Cannot move while absorbing.
Binary Mode (button 4)	Start	Unleash absorbed energy. 10s supercharged state: photon blasts become beams, flight speed doubled, damage +50%. Requires full absorption meter.
Energy Beam	Story mission 1	Hold button 2 to fire sustained energy beam. Higher damage, drains energy meter.
Photon Blast Salvo	Story mission 2	While flying, fire photon blasts in 360° salvo. Crowd control. Cooldown 12s.
Absorb Explosion	Credits: 2,500	When absorption meter is full, release button 3 to explode outward, dealing absorbed damage to all nearby enemies.
Cosmic Awareness	Challenge: absorb 1000 damage total	Passive. Mini-map shows all enemies in 50m radius.

Button Layout (4 buttons)

Left stick = move. **Right stick** = camera/aim.
Button 1 (Vertical Flight, hold) **Button 2 (Photon Blast / hold = Beam)**
Button 3 (Absorb, hold) **Button 4 (Binary Mode)**

Design Notes

Pulsar's absorption mechanic is what makes her feel distinct from a generic blaster. The fantasy is "I get stronger the more you hit me," which encourages aggressive play (run into the fight, absorb damage, unleash Binary Mode). Her vertical flight pose (Superman-style) is deliberately distinct from Ironclad's horizontal flight and Mystic's levitation — three flyers, three silhouettes. She is also the best hero for vehicle emergencies that involve crashing planes (catch the plane, absorb the impact).

5.8 Elasto — The Elastic

Archetype: Stretchy rubber-limbed genius. **Color:** Blue uniform with white gloves and "4" emblem. **Personality:** Nerdy, problem-solver, treats combat like a puzzle.

Power Kit

Elasto stretches up to 1500 feet, deforms his body into any shape, and uses his elasticity for both combat and traversal. His signature mechanic is **shape-shift hands**: he reconfigures his hands into a hammer, shield, whip, or glider on demand. He can flatten his body to glide, inflate himself as a boulder for ground slams, and slingshot allies across the map. He is the roster's versatile hero — jack of all trades, master of puzzle-solving.

Power	Unlock	Description
Stretch Punch (button 1)	Start	Elongate arm to punch enemies at range (up to 30m). Returns. Cooldown 1s.
Flatten Glide (button 2, hold)	Start	Flatten body into a parachute-like sheet. Controlled descent from any height.
Shape-Shift Hand (button 3, cycle)	Start	Cycle hand form: Hammer (heavy melee), Shield (block), Whip (catch enemies at range), Glider (improve flatten glide).
Slingshot (button 4)	Start	Anchor feet, stretch backward, release to fling forward. Rapid traversal. Can slingshot allies too.
Inflate Body	Story mission 1	Inflate into a giant boulder. Roll over enemies. Ground slam on release.
Multi-Arm	Story mission 2	Sprout 4 extra arms. Stretch-punch 5 enemies simultaneously for 5s.
Containment Wrap	Credits: 2,000	Wrap an enemy in elastic limbs. Immobilize for 4s. Cooldown 10s.
Slingshot Ally	Challenge: slingshot 20 civilians to safety	Slingshot any ally across the map. Used in duo missions to launch partner into battle.

Button Layout (4 buttons)

Left stick = move. Right stick = camera/aim.
Button 1 (Stretch Punch) Button 2 (Flatten Glide, hold)
Button 3 (Shape-Shift Hand, cycle) Button 4 (Slingshot)

Design Notes

Elasto is the most experimental hero — his shape-shifting hand mechanic is unusual for mobile games. The cycle button (tap to cycle through 4 forms) was chosen over a radial menu because radial menus are slow on touchscreens. The form is shown as a small icon on the button itself, so the player always knows what form is active. Elasto's fantasy is "I have a tool for every problem" — he is the puzzle-solver, the hero you bring to missions with weird mechanics (containment, civilian relocation, multi-target takedowns).

5.9 Sentinel / Hollow — The Duality

Archetype: God-tier hero with a dark alter-ego. Inspired by Sentry/Void. **Color:** Gold and white (Sentinel) / black and purple (Hollow). **Personality:** Sentinel is gentle, haunted, afraid of his own power. Hollow is cruel, destructive, delighted by chaos.

Power Kit

Sentinel is the most powerful hero in the roster — and the most dangerous to play. His **duality meter** fills as he uses his abilities. At 50%, he can toggle into Hollow form (more powerful, but drains his health). At 100%, Hollow takes over completely (player loses control for 10s; Hollow attacks everything, including allies). The fantasy is a hero holding back, and the player must choose when to unleash the Hollow. Sentinel is the central figure of the campaign story.

Power	Unlock	Description
Flight (button 1, hold)	Start	Standard 3D flight. No special pose — Sentinel simply floats.
Light Blast (button 2)	Start	Fires concentrated light beam. High damage, narrow. Cooldown 2s.
Super Strength (button 3)	Start	Melee with god-tier strength. Lifts and throws cars, mechs, enemies.
Hollow Toggle (button 4)	Start	At 50%+ duality meter, toggle into Hollow form. Hollow abilities replace Sentinel abilities. Drains health while active.
Hollow Tendrils (Hollow form, button 2)	Start (in Hollow)	Black tendrils strike up to 5 enemies at range.
Hollow Reality Warp (Hollow form, button 3)	Story mission 1	Bend space. Teleport short distances, reflect projectiles.
Hollow Aura (Hollow form, button 1)	Story mission 2	Passive damage aura. All enemies in 5m take continuous damage.
Sentinel Aura	Credits: 3,500	In Sentinel form, passive heal aura. Allies in 5m slowly regenerate health.
Hollow Purge	Challenge: defeat 200 enemies in Hollow form	When duality meter hits 100%, instead of losing control, Hollow Purge triggers: massive AoE blast, meter resets to 0. Player keeps control.

Button Layout (4 buttons)

Left stick = move. Right stick = camera/aim.

Button 1 (Flight / Hollow Aura) Button 2 (Light Blast / Hollow Tendrils)

Button 3 (Super Strength / Hollow Reality Warp) Button 4 (Hollow Toggle)

Design Notes

Sentinel is the campaign's emotional core. His arc is about a man terrified of his own power, and the player feels that terror mechanically: every use of his abilities brings him closer to losing control. The Hollow Purge challenge reward is the most satisfying unlock in the game — it transforms Sentinel from a hero to manage into a hero to unleash. He is also the hardest hero to play well, because greed (using Hollow too long) gets the player killed. This makes him the expert-hero of the roster, the one veteran players gravitate to.

5.10 Mystic — The Sorcerer

Archetype: Master of the mystic arts. **Color:** Dark red cape with arcane gold trim. **Personality:** Cryptic, dry-witted, carries secrets he should not.

Power Kit

Mystic is the roster's spellcaster. His flight is vertical levitation (no flight pose, just floating upward). His signature ability is **portals**: open a portal in front of him and another anywhere in line-of-sight, walk through to teleport. He has telekinesis (lift and throw objects/enemies), time rewind (rewind the last 3 seconds of gameplay), and a mirror-dimension shield that absorbs projectiles. He is the puzzle-mission hero — many of his story missions involve portal-based platforming.

Power	Unlock	Description
Portal (button 1)	Start	Open portal entry (at Mystic) and exit (at aimed location). Walk through to teleport. Cooldown 5s.
Levitate (button 2, hold)	Start	Vertical flight. Float upward, hover, drift horizontally. No speed, full control.
Telekinesis (button 3)	Start	Lift and throw any object or enemy. Aim, lift, throw. Cooldown 4s.
Time Rewind (button 4)	Start	Rewind the last 3 seconds of gameplay. Restore health, undo mistakes. Cooldown 60s.
Mirror Dimension Shield	Story mission 1	Wrap self in mirror dimension. Projectiles pass through harmlessly. 5s duration.
Portal Punch	Story mission 2	Open a portal behind an enemy, punch through it. Hits from "behind" ignore shields.
Mass Telekinesis	Credits: 3,000	Lift all objects in 15m radius simultaneously. Throw them all at one target.
Time Stop	Challenge: defeat 50 enemies with telekinesis throws	Stop time for 5s in 20m radius. Only Mystic can move. Cooldown 90s.

Button Layout (4 buttons)

Left stick = move. **Right stick** = camera/aim.
Button 1 (Portal) **Button 2 (Levitate, hold)**
Button 3 (Telekinesis) **Button 4 (Time Rewind)**

Design Notes

Mystic is the puzzle-mission hero. His portal mechanic enables level design that no other hero can engage with — maze-like missions, time-pressure platforming, shield-puzzle combat. His story missions are the most mechanically distinct in the campaign. His time rewind is the only "undo" in the game and is deliberately long-cooldown (60s) so it feels like a precious resource, not a quickload. He also holds story secrets — the campaign reveals he knows more about The Hollow than anyone, and a mid-Act-2 mission forces the player to confront him about it.

6. Suit System (Cosmetic Only)

6.1 Design Rule: Suits Do Not Change Abilities

A hard design rule, set by the owner: **suits are cosmetic only**. A suit does not unlock new abilities, change stats, or alter gameplay. The owner wears what looks cool. Ability progression is handled entirely through the Ability Progression System (Section 7), which is independent of suits. This avoids the design trap of "the best suit is the one I don't like the look of" — players can wear their favorite suit without gameplay penalty.

6.2 How Suits Are Acquired

Suits are acquired through five channels, ensuring that every playstyle has a path to cosmetic rewards. None of these paths involve real-money purchase (the game is a personal project with no monetization). All suits are equally cosmetic — there is no "rarity" tier that implies one suit is better than another.

Channel	How	Example
Story Progression	Unlocked automatically by reaching story beats	Velora's "Classic" suit (unlocked at hero unlock)
Mission Rewards	Completing specific missions with optional objectives	Arachne's "Stealth Suit" (complete mission 4 undetected)
Collectibles	Finding hidden tokens in the open world	Ironclad's "Bleeding Edge" suit (find all 10 tech tokens in Midtown)
Challenge Completion	Completing hero-specific gameplay challenges	Sentinel's "Hollow Form" suit (defeat 200 enemies in Hollow form)
Milestones	Reaching gameplay milestones	Pulsar's "Binary Form" suit (absorb 10,000 damage total)

6.3 Suit Count Per Hero

Each hero has a target of **5-8 suits** at launch, totaling 50-80 suits across the roster. This is a substantial collectathon goal for the owner. Suits are the primary long-term cosmetic reward. Each suit can be previewed in the HQ Wardrobe before equipping.

6.4 Suit Selection UI

Suits can be changed in two places: (1) the **HQ Wardrobe** at The Citadel, where the full roster is previewed in 3D; and (2) the **Hero Phone Suit Selector**, accessible mid-mission, which plays a 2-second transformation animation and applies the new suit. Mid-mission suit swaps are instant — no penalty, no cooldown — because suits do not affect gameplay.

7. Ability Progression System

7.1 Three Channels of Ability Unlock

Abilities are unlocked through three independent channels. Every hero uses all three channels, so the player always has multiple progression tracks active. The hybrid system avoids the failure modes of pure approaches: pure-mission unlocks feel slow and gate the fun; pure-currency unlocks feel grindy. The hybrid approach keeps the player always near a meaningful unlock.

Channel	What It Unlocks	Why It Exists
Story Missions	Each hero's core kit and signature abilities. ~4 unlocks per hero.	Creates narrative payoff. Story beats feel rewarding because they grant new toys.
In-Game Currency (Credits)	Side abilities, upgrades, and customization. Earned from any mission.	Gives the player choice in their build. Makes side crimes worth doing. Player-directed progression.
Challenge Unlocks	Special abilities tied to specific gameplay feats.	Skill-based unlocks feel earned. Rewards mastery of a hero.

7.2 Credits — In-Game Currency

Credits are earned from every mission. The payout scales with mission difficulty and optional objectives. Credits are spent at the HQ Ability Console or via the Hero Phone. There is no real-money purchase of Credits — the game has no monetization. Credits are also used for suit purchases from the Wardrobe (cosmetic only) and for upgrading existing abilities (e.g., +10% damage, -15% cooldown).

Mission Type	Payout Range	Notes
Story mission (first completion)	500-1000	One-time. Higher payouts for longer missions.
Crime-in-Progress (easy)	50-150	Repeatable. Fast spawns.
Crime-in-Progress (medium)	150-300	Repeatable.
Crime-in-Progress (hard)	300-500	Repeatable.
Duo mission (first completion)	800-1200	One-time per designed duo.
Assemble mission	1500-2500	Big payouts.
Daily challenge	300-500	Once per day.
Weekly challenge	1000-1500	Once per week.
Roguelike rift (per floor cleared)	100/floor	Endgame grind.

7.3 Upgrade Trees

Each hero has an upgrade tree with three branches: **Power** (more damage), **Speed** (faster cooldowns, faster movement), and **Utility** (extra effects, longer durations, larger areas). Upgrades cost Credits and require the base ability to be unlocked first. Each ability has 3 upgrade tiers. The owner can respec at the HQ Ability Console for free — no penalty for experimentation.

7.4 Challenge Unlocks

Challenge unlocks are the most prestigious abilities in the game. They require the player to demonstrate mastery of a hero. Examples include Velora's Air-Run (run on water for 30s without stopping), Sentinel's Hollow Purge (defeat 200 enemies in Hollow form), and Mystic's Time Stop (defeat 50 enemies with telekinesis throws). These abilities are intentionally the most powerful in each hero's kit — the reward for mastery is a meaningful power spike.

8. World & Locations

8.1 Multi-District Open World

Pantheon features a multi-district open world, larger than Spider Fighter 3's single map. Four districts are available at launch, each with its own visual identity, crime patterns, and hero-affinity. Districts are connected seamlessly — the player can run, fly, swing, or drive between them without loading screens (border crossings have a brief 1-second transition). Fast-travel between districts is available via the Hero Phone map.

District	Theme	Architecture	Crime Pattern	Hero Affinity
Midtown	Downtown skyscrapers, business district	Tall glass towers, dense streets, corporate plazas	Bank heists, corporate espionage, villain attacks	Ironclad, Arachne, Aegis Wing
Chinatown	Dense streets, neon signs, markets	Narrow alleys, low buildings, lanterns, food stalls	Store robberies, gang wars, smuggling rings	Arachne, Glitch, Mystic
Sand Town	Desert edge, dusty, scrapyards	Low industrial buildings, junk piles, dust storms	Bandit raids, weapons deals, vehicle chases	Aegis Wing, Stormborn, Elasto
Beach City	Coastline, piers, boardwalks	Hotels, beachfront, docks, lighthouses	Boat hijackings, smuggling, sea-based threats	Pulsar, Aegis Wing, Velora (water-run)

8.2 Living World Systems

Each district is a living world with persistent systems running independently of the player. Traffic flows on schedules, civilians go about routines, day cycles into night, and crimes spawn based on time-of-day patterns (more street crimes at night, more corporate crimes during business hours). The player is never the only thing happening in the city — the city has its own life.

System	Description
Day/Night Cycle	Full 24-hour cycle compressed to 2 hours real-time. Crimes and ambient behavior shift with time.
Weather	Rain (wet reflective streets), fog, clear, storms. Weather affects visibility and some abilities.
Traffic	Cars, buses, trucks flow on streets following traffic AI. Accidents cause jams. Getaway cars spawn from traffic.
Pedestrians	Dense crowds. Panicked flee from crimes. Some become victims needing rescue.
Trains	Bullet trains run on elevated tracks on fixed schedules. Cross-district transit.
Boats	Cargo ships, ferries, smuggling boats traverse coastline and rivers.
Planes	Passenger jets fly overhead on flight paths. Always visible in the sky.

System	Description
Police	NPC police respond to crimes independently. Will engage enemies but be outmatched. Heroes assist.

8.3 Future Districts (Post-Launch)

- **Neon District** — Cyberpunk-themed. Glitch's home turf. Holographic ads, vertical streets, drone traffic.
- **Mystic Quarter** — Floating temples, weird physics, inverted gravity zones. Mystic's domain.
- **Industrial Zone** — Factories, smog, smokestacks. Titan and Elasto playground.
- **North Ridge** — Snowy mountains. Year-round winter event zone.
- **Mirror Dimension** — Endgame roguelike zone. Reality is broken. Only Mystic (and post-game, others) can enter.

8.4 The Citadel (HQ)

The Citadel is the Pantheon HQ — a SHIELD-style helicarrier hovering above the city. It serves as the player's hub between missions. From The Citadel, the player accesses the Wardrobe (suit selection), Ability Console (upgrades), War Room (mission select), Hero Roster (hero switch), Training Room (practice against bots), Vault (collectibles and lore), and AI Console (tips and dialogue). The Citadel is also where story cutscenes play and where the Director briefs the player.

9. Vehicle Emergencies

9.1 Vehicle Systems Make the World Feel Alive

Vehicle emergencies are a major differentiator from Spider Fighter 3, which has no meaningful vehicle gameplay. In Pantheon, planes fly overhead constantly, trains run on schedules, boats traverse the coastline, and ground vehicles fill the streets. Any of these vehicles can become an emergency at any time. The player receives a phone alert, chooses whether to respond, and travels to the scene. Vehicle emergencies are higher-stakes than street crimes because they involve civilians in immediate danger and often have timers.

9.2 Plane Emergencies

Planes spawn every ~10 minutes somewhere in the sky, flying normally between airports. When an emergency triggers, the player has 60-90 seconds to reach the plane before it crashes. Flying heroes (Ironclad, Pulsar, Sentinel, Aegis Wing) can intercept; Velora can air-run to reach them; others must use alternative methods (Arachne web-zip to a tall building, then web-wing glide to intercept).

Emergency Type	Mechanic	Best Heroes
Hijacked passenger jet	Storm the cockpit mid-flight, fight hijackers, retake controls, land safely.	Ironclad, Aegis Wing, Arachne
Engine failure	Catch the plane before it crashes. Hold it aloft while it restarts. Strength check.	Pulsar (absorb impact), Sentinel, Stormborn
Villain attacking from outside	Aerial dogfight. Engage villain on the plane's hull. Avoid damaging the plane.	Ironclad, Pulsar, Stormborn
Cargo door open, civilians falling	Catch falling civilians mid-air. Time-pressure. Multiple civilians.	Aegis Wing (Aerial Escort), Arachne (web-yank), Velora (air-run)
Bomb on board	Defuse bomb + evacuate passengers. Two simultaneous objectives.	Any hero (defuse) + Aegis Wing (evac)

9.3 Train Emergencies

Trains run on elevated tracks connecting districts. They follow fixed schedules visible on the Hero Phone map. Train emergencies are time-sensitive — the train keeps moving while the emergency unfolds, and the player must keep up.

Emergency Type	Mechanic
Hijacked bullet train	Fight through cars, defeat hijackers, stop train before derailment.
Bomb on board	Defuse + evacuate. Train keeps moving. Civilian timer.
Train about to collide	Push train to a stop. Strength check (Titan, Stormborn, Sentinel).
Villain on top of train	Top-of-train fight scene. Wind resistance, low ceiling tunnels.

Emergency Type	Mechanic
Track obstruction	Clear the track ahead of the train. Race against the train.

9.4 Boat Emergencies

Boats traverse the coastline and rivers. Cargo ships, ferries, smuggling boats, and yachts each have different emergency types. Boat emergencies are the slowest vehicle emergencies — boats take longer to reach and longer to resolve.

Emergency Type	Mechanic
Piracy / hijacking on cargo ship	Takedown pirates, secure crew. Multi-stage.
Sinking ship	Rescue civilians before ship goes down. Plunge timer.
Smuggler boats evading	Chase + intercept. Aegis Wing flyover, Velora water-run, Arachne web-yank from bridge.
Sea monster / Kraken summon	Boss fight at sea. Mystic-faction villain.
Oil spill	Contain spill before it reaches shore. Velora tornado blows oil back.

9.5 Ground Vehicle Emergencies

Ground vehicles are the most common vehicle emergency. Cars, trucks, buses, and motorcycles fill the streets and frequently become crime scenes. These are the fastest vehicle emergencies to resolve — usually under 2 minutes.

Emergency Type	Mechanic
Bank robbery getaway chase	Stop the getaway car. Ram, intercept, or land on it.
Armored truck heist	Protect the truck from multiple attackers. Tower-defense style.
Villain convoy	Multiple vehicles. Take them all down in sequence.
Bus hostage situation	Board the bus, neutralize hijackers, no civilian casualties.
School bus in danger	Highest-priority emergency. Timer is short. Escort the bus to safety.

9.6 Travel Time Matters

A critical design rule: **travel time to vehicle emergencies is part of the gameplay**. Plane emergencies favor flying heroes because they can reach the sky fastest. Boat emergencies favor flyers or Velora (water-run). Train emergencies favor Velora (catch up to the moving train) or Arachne (web-swing alongside). This means no single hero is best for all vehicle emergencies — the player is encouraged to switch heroes based on the emergency type, which is core to the roster fantasy.

10. Crime System

10.1 Procedural Crime-in-Progress (Layer 2)

The Crime-in-Progress system is the game's procedural content engine. Crimes spawn continuously in every district, ranging from minor street crimes to major supervillain sightings. The player receives phone alerts and can choose which to respond to. Each crime is procedurally varied: location, enemy count, time of day, weather, civilian count, and optional objectives all roll randomly within templates. The same template produces hundreds of unique-feeling encounters.

10.2 Crime Catalog

Crime	District	Difficulty	Hero Fit
Bank robbery	Midtown	Medium	Any
Store robbery	Chinatown, Beach City	Easy	Any
Fire starting (arsonist)	Any residential	Easy-Medium	Velora (tornado), Aegis Wing
Getaway car chase	Any	Easy	Velora, Arachne
Gang fight	Chinatown, Sand Town	Easy	Any
Bomb threat	Any	Medium	Any
Hostage situation	Any	Medium	Any
Tech heist	Midtown	Medium	Glitch, Ironclad
Boat piracy	Beach City	Medium-Hard	Aegis Wing, Pulsar
Plane emergency	Sky	Hard	Ironclad, Pulsar, Sentinel
Train emergency	Cross-district	Medium-Hard	Velora, Arachne
Supervillain sighting	Any	Hard	Duo
Portal breach	Any	Hard	Duo
Factory sabotage	Industrial (future)	Medium	Titan, Elasto
Cult ritual	Mystic Quarter (future)	Hard	Mystic, Sentinel
Helicopter hijack	Any	Medium-Hard	Ironclad, Aegis Wing
Tsunami warning	Beach City	Hard	Pulsar, Stormborn
Power grid attack	Midtown	Medium	Ironclad, Glitch
School bus in danger	Any	Medium (priority)	Any
Ambulance escort	Any	Easy	Any

10.3 Crime Spawning Logic

Crimes spawn on a tick — every 30-90 seconds, a new crime spawns somewhere in the open world. The crime type is weighted by district (bank robberies more likely in Midtown, store robberies in Chinatown, boat piracy in Beach City) and time of day (more street crimes at night, more corporate crimes by day). Up to 5 crimes can be active simultaneously. If the player ignores a crime, it eventually resolves itself (police handle it) or fails (civilians harmed) — the world does not wait for the player.

10.4 Optional Objectives

Every crime has 1-3 optional objectives that grant bonus Credits and contribute to challenge unlocks. Examples: "Complete without taking damage," "Rescue all civilians," "Defeat all enemies in under 60 seconds," "Use only melee attacks." Optional objectives are the primary replay incentive for crimes — completing the same crime with all optional objectives grants 3x the Credits.

11. Mission Architecture (5 Layers)

11.1 Story vs Mission Systems — Critical Distinction

The **Story Campaign** and the **Mission Architecture** are different things that overlap. The Story Campaign is a scripted, linear, one-time narrative of 25 missions with cutscenes, dialogue, the Director/Hollow plot, and a final choice. It takes ~15 hours to complete and is played once. The Mission Architecture is the system that GENERATES missions — and the Story is just one of five layers. The other four layers run during AND after the story, providing infinite replayability.

During the story: Story missions play out, but crimes keep spawning, duo missions unlock, and one assemble mission hits at Act 2 climax + another at Act 3 finale.

After the story: The 25 story missions are done forever. But the city keeps living — crimes still spawn, duo missions rotate weekly, new assemble missions appear as live-ops events, roguelike rifts open, daily challenges refresh, NG+ unlocks. The game never "ends."

11.2 Layer 1: Story Campaign (Linear, 25 Missions)

The story campaign is ~25 missions split across three acts. Each mission advances the plot, has scripted dialogue and cutscenes, and unlocks new heroes or abilities. Story missions cannot be replayed in normal play (NG+ unlocks replay with scaled-up enemies). Act structure: Act 1 (missions 1-8, recruitment), Act 2 (missions 9-17, faction war + Director reveal), Act 3 (missions 18-25, Hollow rises + finale choice).

11.3 Layer 2: Crime-in-Progress (Procedural, Infinite)

See Section 10. Crimes spawn continuously in every district. Procedural variation in location, enemy count, time of day, weather, civilians, and optional objectives means the same template produces hundreds of unique-feeling missions. Crimes run during AND after the story.

11.4 Layer 3: Duo Partner Missions (Designed Pairs)

Duo missions require two specific heroes because their powers synergize. The player controls one hero; the AI controls the other (co-op in Phase 4). Each duo mission has unique combo finishers only that pair can perform. Some duo missions are part of the story campaign; others unlock post-story and rotate weekly.

Mission	Pair	Why Paired
Storm & Speed	Velora + Stormborn	Velora races ahead to disarm bombs while Stormborn handles the army.
Tech & Magic	Ironclad + Mystic	Science vs magic. Portals + repulsors. Banter-heavy.
Brains & Brawn	Glitch + Titan	Glitch disables security while Titan smashes through.
Web & Wing	Arachne + Aegis Wing	Both aerial. Chase a flying villain across the city.
Light & Dark	Pulsar + Sentinel	Energy absorber + reality warper. Cosmic-level threat.
Stretch & Smash	Elasto + Titan	Slingshot each other for combo attacks.

Mission	Pair	Why Paired
Old Soldier, Young Hero	Aegis Wing + Arachne	Mentor/mentee dynamic. Classic team-up.

11.5 Layer 4: Assemble Missions (Full Team)

Assemble missions are the big set-pieces. The campaign has 3-4 of these (Act 1 climax, Act 2 climax, Act 3 finale). Post-story, assemble missions rotate as weekly live-ops events. The player swaps heroes mid-mission as the situation evolves.

Mission	Description
City Under Siege	Full villain army attacks the city. Play 3 heroes in sequence, swapping as the front shifts.
The Void Rises	Hollow (dark Sentinel) escapes. All 10 heroes in multi-phase boss fight. Each phase, only certain heroes' powers work.
Invasion Day	Alien invasion. Time-limited weekly event. All players contribute to global progress.
Mirror Dimension Collapse	Reality is breaking. Hero-swap every 60s. Each hero must complete a mini-objective in their domain.
The Pantheon Protocol	Endgame raid. 5 phases. Each requires a different hero combination.

11.6 Layer 5: Replayability Engines

Five systems generate content forever. These run alongside Layers 1-4 and keep the game alive after the story ends. See Section 18 for full detail.

Engine	Lifespan
Daily & Weekly Challenges	Infinite (refreshes daily/weekly)
Suit Hunt (Collectathon)	~20 hours to collect all 50-80 suits
Roguelike Mode: "Hollow Rifts"	Infinite (procedurally generated floors)
Endless Mode: "Patrol"	Infinite (score attack)
New Game+ (NG+)	+15 hours (replay story with all suits, scaled enemies)

11.7 Replayability Summary

A completionist player pursuing all content will find 60+ hours of gameplay. After completion, infinite replayability remains through roguelike rifts, daily challenges, and live-ops events. The game does not "end" when the credits roll — it opens up. This directly addresses the owner's concern that "if they complete the game it becomes boring."

12. Enemy Factions (5)

12.1 Faction Design

Pantheon features five enemy factions, each with a unique theme, lead villain, and roster of enemy types. Factions operate independently in the open world — The Syndicate runs street crime in Midtown, the Tech Cult hacks infrastructure in Chinatown, the Mystic Order summons demons in hidden temples, and so on. The story campaign reveals that all five factions are being manipulated from behind the scenes by Director Vance (the twist).

Faction	Theme	Lead Villain	District
The Syndicate	Street criminals, mobsters, enforcers	Kingmaker (crime boss)	Midtown, Sand Town
Tech Cult	Hackers, drones, mechs, robots	ZeroDay (Glitch's evil counterpart)	Chinatown, Neon District
Mystic Order	Cultists, demons, summoned beasts	Shadow-weaver (Mystic's evil counterpart)	Mystic Quarter, hidden temples
Cosmic Threat	Aliens, energy beings	Eclipse (Pulsar's evil counterpart)	Beach City, sky
The Hollow	Dark Sentinel's shadow monsters	The Hollow (Sentinel's alter-ego)	Anywhere (event-driven)

12.2 Enemy Tiers

Every faction has five tiers of enemies, from cannon fodder to mini-bosses. Tier design is consistent across factions so the player learns the visual language (tier 1 = small and weak, tier 5 = big and dangerous) and can read encounters regardless of which faction they're fighting.

Tier	Example	Behavior	Threat
1 - Minion	Street Thug / Drone	Melee, swarm, low HP	Low
2 - Ranged	Gunner / Laser Drone	Stays back, shoots	Low-Medium
3 - Brute	Enforcer / Mech	Slow, heavy, high HP, knockback	Medium
4 - Specialist	Hacker (disables abilities 3s) / Shield-bearer (immune to frontal)	Forces tactical adaptation	High
5 - Elite	Named mini-boss	Unique mechanics, drop loot	Very High

12.3 Faction-Specific Mechanics

Each faction has a unique combat mechanic that distinguishes encounters. This prevents all enemy fights from feeling the same and forces the player to adapt their hero choice and tactics based on which faction they're facing.

Faction	Unique Mechanic
The Syndicate	Numerical superiority. Swarms of low-HP enemies. AoE heroes excel.
Tech Cult	Hackable tech. Glitch can turn their own mechs against them. EMP-vulnerable.
Mystic Order	Mirror dimension shifts. Reality bends during fights. Mystic-faction only fully effective.
Cosmic Threat	Energy-absorbing enemies. Pulsar's absorption race reversed — enemies absorb her blasts.
The Hollow	Duality mechanic. Enemies shift between light/dark forms. Only one form is damageable at a time.

13. Boss Design (10 Bosses)

13.1 One Boss Per Hero

Each of the 10 heroes has a nemesis — a boss designed specifically to test that hero's kit. Boss fights are multi-phase (3+ phases), have a hero-specific mechanic that only that hero's powers can solve, and include a mid-fight suit-switch moment (cosmetic, but signals the phase change). Each boss ends with a cinematic slow-mo finisher.

Boss	Counter-Hero	Boss Mechanic
Kingmaker	Aegis Wing	Brute fight. Throws objects, summons minions. Must ricochet shield off walls to hit weak point on his back.
ZeroDay	Glitch	Hacks your controls (buttons remap randomly for 3s). Drone swarm. EMP bursts. Must counter-hack her systems.
Shadow-weaver	Mystic	Mirror dimension fight. Portal puzzles between phases. Must redirect her own spells through portals.
Eclipse	Pulsar	Energy absorption race. Out-pace her or she heals. Must dodge her blasts to charge your own meter faster.
The Hollow	Sentinel	Duality meter fight. Phases shift between Sentinel form (light weak) and Hollow form (dark weak).
Venomfang	Arachne	Symbiote. Camouflages, counters web. Must use Spider-Sense Dodge timing to expose weak point.
Crimson Dynamo	Ironclad	Armor duel. Must exploit weak points (joint gaps) with repulsor precision shots. AI Assist marks weak points.
Godspeed	Velora	Speed duel. Slow-time race through falling debris maze. Phase 2: pure chase across the city.
Trickster	Stormborn	Illusions + clones. Must find the real Trickster among 5 clones. Hammer throw reveals the real one.
Titan-Killer	Elasto / Sentinel	Giant mech. Shadow-of-the-Colossus-style climb-on-body fight. Destroy joints from inside.

13.2 Boss Fight Design Rules

- **Multi-phase (3+ phases)** — each phase has different mechanics. Phase transitions trigger at HP thresholds (66%, 33%).
- **Hero-specific mechanic** — only the counter-hero's kit can complete a key phase. Other heroes can fight but cannot finish.
- **Cinematic finisher** — final blow triggers a slow-mo cinematic. Unique per boss. Reusable in NG+.
- **No health sponges** — bosses have meaningful HP but phases are about mechanics, not DPS checks.

- **Limited adds** — bosses summon minions in controlled waves. Never overwhelming. Minions are phase transitions, not constant.
- **Checkpoint per phase** — if player dies at phase 2, they restart at phase 2, not phase 1.

13.3 Final Boss: The Hollow (Assemble Mission)

The campaign's final boss is The Hollow — Sentinel's dark half fully unleashed. This is an assemble mission where all 10 heroes participate across 5 phases. Each phase, only certain heroes' powers can damage The Hollow. The player swaps heroes between phases. The finale choice (destroy the Godstone vs preserve Sentinel) plays after the final phase.

14. HQ & Hero Phone Systems

14.1 The Citadel (HQ)

The Citadel is the Pantheon HQ — a helicarrier hovering above the city. It serves as the hub between missions. The player accesses it from the Hero Phone (instant fast-travel) or by flying up to it in the open world. The Citadel contains several rooms, each with a specific function.

Room	Function
Wardrobe	Try on/switch suits, see unlock requirements, preview in 3D.
Ability Console	Spend Credits on upgrades, respec for free, view challenge progress.
War Room	Pick story missions, see world map with active crime hotspots, accept weekly challenges.
Hero Roster	Switch active hero. View all unlocked heroes. See unlock requirements for locked heroes.
Training Room	Practice each hero's kit against bots. Tutorial mode. Combo practice.
Vault	Collectibles, lore documents, concept art, cutscene replay.
AI Console	Talk to AI assistant for tips, hero recommendations for missions, lore questions.
Briefing Room	Story cutscenes play here. Director gives mission briefings.

14.2 Hero Phone

The Hero Phone is the diegetic UI accessible mid-game. Tapping the phone button (top-right corner of screen) overlays the phone UI without pausing the game. The phone contains several apps, each with a specific function. The phone is the primary way to interact with mission systems without returning to The Citadel.

App	Function
Mission Alerts	Crime-in-progress notifications. Accept/decline. Filter by district or difficulty.
Suit Selector	Quick-swap suit mid-mission. 2-second transformation animation. No gameplay effect.
City Map	Live map with active crime hotspots, vehicle schedules (planes/trains/boats), and fast-travel.
HQ Comms	Director briefings. Hero-to-hero comms in duo missions. Call for HQ support (rare, mission-specific).
Stats & Skill Tree	View hero stats, upgrade tree, challenge progress.
Daily/Weekly Challenges	View active challenges, progress, rewards.
Hero Roster	Switch active hero mid-mission (with 5-second cooldown).

14.3 Phone Design Rules

- **Never pauses the game** — opening the phone is a tactical decision. The world keeps moving.
- **Always one tap away** — phone button is permanently in the top-right corner. Never hidden.
- **Quick-actions** — most-used functions (suit swap, hero swap, accept mission) are one tap deep.
- **Voice alerts** — Director speaks mission alerts aloud. Phone shows them as text too.
- **Hero-to-hero comms** — in duo missions, the partner hero speaks through the phone. Banter plays here.

15. UI & Controls (Hero-Specific)

15.1 Touch Controls Architecture

Pantheon uses a twin-stick touch control scheme: a left virtual joystick (move) and a right virtual joystick (camera/aim), both implemented with nipples. Action buttons are DOM elements arranged in a semicircle around the right joystick. The number of action buttons varies by hero — Velora has 5, Stormborn has 4, Ironclad has 5, etc. This hero-specific button count is a deliberate design rule.

15.2 Why Hero-Specific Button Counts

A common mobile-game mistake is forcing all heroes into a fixed 4-button layout (A/B/X/Y). This leads to one of two failures: either some heroes have dead buttons (bad — feels unfinished) or some heroes cram too many abilities onto too few buttons via hold/tap modifiers (bad — feels fiddly). Pantheon's solution is to let each hero have the button count their kit demands. Velora needs 5 because she has Jog AND Sprint as separate buttons (per owner spec). Stormborn needs only 4 because his kit is elegant. The player learns each hero's layout in the Training Room before field deployment.

15.3 Universal UI Elements

Regardless of which hero is active, certain UI elements are always present and always in the same location. This creates a consistent frame that the player can rely on while the hero-specific buttons change.

Element	Location	Function
Left Joystick	Bottom-left	Move (always).
Right Joystick	Bottom-right	Camera + aim (always).
Hero Portrait + Health	Top-left	Hero face, health bar, duality meter (if Sentinel).
Mini-Map	Top-right	Live district map with crime hotspots.
Mission Tracker	Below mini-map	Current mission objective + distance.
Phone Button	Top-right corner	Always accessible. Opens phone UI.
Action Buttons	Arc around right joystick	Hero-specific. 4-5 buttons.
Pause Button	Top-left corner	Pauses game. Settings. Quit.

15.4 Button Layouts Per Hero

Each hero's button layout is documented in their hero section (Section 5). The layouts are designed so that the most-used abilities are easiest to reach (closest to the right joystick), and situational abilities are further out. Hold-to-modify buttons (e.g., Ironclad's "tap = Vertical Launch, hold = Horizontal Flight") are used sparingly — only when the two abilities are clearly related.

15.5 Input Latency Budget

Touch input latency is the single most important performance metric for a mobile action game. Pantheon targets <60ms input-to-action latency. The right joystick (camera) is the most latency-sensitive — any delay causes motion sickness. Action buttons allow 80ms (slightly less critical). All input is processed on the main thread, before rendering, to avoid frame-delay.

16. Art Direction

16.1 Visual Style: Stylized Realism

Pantheon's visual style is "stylized realism" — a middle ground between photorealism (too expensive, ages badly) and cartoon stylization (too childish for the story's tone). The reference frame is **Spider-Man: Into the Spider-Verse** meets **Insomniac's Spider-Man PS4**: realistic lighting, PBR materials, dynamic shadows, and weather effects, but characters have slightly exaggerated proportions and bold color palettes that read clearly at phone-screen sizes. This approach looks polished, runs smoothly on mobile hardware, and ages well over time.

16.2 Comparison to Spider Fighter 3

Spider Fighter 3 is visually rough: flat textures, basic geometry, limited lighting. Pantheon will exceed it on every visual axis. The following comparison is honest — we cannot match AAA console graphics, but we can absolutely beat a \$0 mobile game.

Aspect	Spider Fighter 3	Pantheon	Verdict
City detail	Flat textures, basic buildings	PBR materials, dynamic lighting, reflective glass, day/night	Pantheon wins
Character models	Stylized mobile-quality	Stylized but higher-poly, better animations	Pantheon wins
Physics	Basic swing, no real momentum	Rapier physics — true momentum, weight, ragdoll	Pantheon wins
Combat feel	Floaty, simple	Hit reactions, impact frames, slow-mo finishers	Pantheon wins
Crowds/civilians	Sparse	Dense crowds with panic AI (flee from crime)	Pantheon wins
Traffic	Few cars	Persistent traffic + planes + trains + boats	Pantheon wins significantly
Destruction	None	Destructible props (chairs, windows, cars dent)	Pantheon wins
Weather	Static	Rain (wet streets reflect), fog, storms	Pantheon wins
Day/night	Limited	Full cycle, crimes change by time	Pantheon wins
Cutscenes	Minimal	Cinematic camera, dialogue, banter	Pantheon wins

16.3 Honest Limits

We will not match AAA console graphics (Spider-Man 2 PS5, etc.) — that is a \$300M budget. We will not have photorealistic faces — stylized characters avoid the uncanny valley. We will exceed Spider Fighter 3's mobile quality easily — that game is visually rough, and Three.js with good art direction beats it without effort. The goal is "best-looking mobile superhero game," not "competitive with PS5 exclusives."

16.4 Hero Silhouettes

Each hero must be identifiable by silhouette alone — even with the camera zoomed out. This is achieved through distinct body shapes, cape/wing/weapon outlines, and unique idle animations. Velora is lithe and leans forward (always ready to run). Stormborn is broad with a hammer at his side. Aegis Wing has wings folded behind. Arachne is crouched with webs at the ready. Ironclad is bulky with glowing palms. Glitch is slim with a drone orbiting. Pulsar hovers with energy aura. Elasto has elongated limbs. Sentinel is statuesque with a glowing aura. Mystic floats with cape billowing.

16.5 Color Language

Each hero has a primary color that identifies them at a glance. Velora = electric blue. Stormborn = royal blue with red cape. Aegis Wing = tactical gray with red/white/blue. Arachne = red and black. Ironclad = crimson and gold. Glitch = cyan with neon green. Pulsar = red, blue, gold. Elasto = blue with white. Sentinel = gold and white (Hollow = black and purple). Mystic = dark red with gold trim. These colors are consistent across all suits — even cosmetic suits retain the hero's primary color identity.

17. Story & Campaign

17.1 Setting

A modern superhero universe. Heroes have existed for ~10 years. The world knows about them. There is a secret government agency called **The Aegis Directive** (SHIELD equivalent) that coordinates hero activity. Their flying HQ is **The Citadel** — a helicarrier. The Pantheon Initiative is a formal team of 10 heroes who operate out of The Citadel, organized by Director Vance.

17.2 The Director

Director Vance is the Nick Fury archetype. Gruff, one eye, wears a long coat, knows more than he tells anyone. He founded the Pantheon Initiative. He is morally grey — not a villain, but willing to make hard calls that the heroes despise. The mid-campaign twist reveals he has been secretly manipulating the factions to gather the Godstone fragments, intending to destroy the Godstone (and Sentinel with it) to permanently end the Hollow threat. His logic is sound; his methods are unforgivable. The player chooses whether to side with him at the finale.

17.3 The Threat: The Hollow

Long ago, a cosmic entity called **The Hollow** tried to consume reality. It was defeated and sealed inside a human vessel — that vessel is **Sentinel**. The Hollow is Sentinel's dark half. As long as Sentinel stays balanced (good), The Hollow sleeps. But someone is trying to wake The Hollow. The campaign's central mystery is who, and why.

17.4 The McGuffin: The Godstone

An ancient cosmic artifact, shattered into **5 fragments** centuries ago. Each fragment was hidden with a different faction. If all 5 are reunited, The Hollow breaks free. The 5 factions don't know what they truly hold — they think the fragments are just powerful relics. But Director Vance is manipulating them to gather the fragments — not to free The Hollow, but to **destroy** The Hollow permanently by destroying the Godstone. He believes killing Sentinel (and The Hollow inside him) is the only way to save the world.

17.5 Three-Act Structure

Act 1: Recruitment (Missions 1-8)

Each of the 10 heroes gets a "recruitment mission" where Director Vance brings them into the Pantheon. These are solo missions with low stakes, designed to introduce each hero's kit. Crime-in-Progress events start appearing in the open world. The Director hints that "something" is moving in the criminal underworld. The first Godstone fragment is mentioned. The tone is light, Marvel-Cinematic.

Act 2: The Faction War (Missions 9-17)

The 5 factions all activate at once, each making a play for power. Duo missions begin (heroes must pair up). Sentinel starts having "episodes" — blackouts, violent outbursts. The Hollow is stirring. Heroes retrieve Fragment 1, then Fragment 2... but each retrieval makes Sentinel worse. Ironclad (tech genius) discovers the Director has been lying about something. Mid-act reveal: The Director is collecting fragments on the side. The heroes fracture — some trust Vance, some don't. The first major Assemble mission hits at the Act 2 climax: "City Under Siege."

Act 3: The Hollow Rises (Missions 18-25)

The Director's plan is exposed. Heroes fracture further — some side with him (sacrifice Sentinel), some refuse (find another way). The Hollow partially breaks free mid-Act 3. Sentinel loses control. Massive destruction. The second Assemble mission: all 10 heroes fight The Hollow together. Each phase requires a specific hero's power to damage The Hollow. Final mission: **The Choice**.

17.6 The Final Choice

Option A: Destroy the Godstone. Sentinel dies. The Hollow dies. World is safe forever. Bittersweet ending. Sentinel's funeral plays. The remaining 9 heroes carry his memory.

Option B: Refuse to sacrifice Sentinel. Heroes must find a way to balance Sentinel's duality permanently. Sentinel lives, but The Hollow can return someday. Hopeful but risky ending. Sentinel walks away from the team to find himself.

17.7 Side Stories (Interwoven)

Hero	Side Arc
Velora	Comes to terms with her power being a gift, not a curse. Saves the team in a key moment with her Air-Run.
Ironclad vs Glitch	Tech rivalry — old money genius vs street-smart hacker. They learn to respect each other in a duo mission.
Arachne & Aegis Wing	Mentor/mentee dynamic. Aegis Wing is a veteran, Arachne is the rookie.
Sentinel	He's terrified of The Hollow. Several missions are him almost losing control. Player must play carefully.
Mystic	Knows more about The Hollow than anyone. Has been holding back information. Confrontation mission mid-Act 2.
Stormborn	Fish-out-of-water comedy. Boisterous thunder god in a modern city. Surprisingly wise when it matters.
Pulsar	Military past catches up with her. A mission reveals her old commander is now a villain.
Elasto	His family (the "Four") are referenced but never appear. Hints at a larger world.

17.8 Tone

The tone is Marvel Cinematic Universe energy: humor, banter, spectacle, but real stakes. Each hero has a distinct personality, they bicker, they bond. The Director is morally grey, not a villain — the player understands his logic even if they disagree. The ending is emotionally weighty, not just "yay we won." The post-credits scene hints at a new faction emerging in the shadows, teasing future content (Neon District, Mystic Quarter, etc.).

18. Replayability Systems

18.1 The "Boring After Completion" Problem

The owner identified the core problem: "if they complete the game it becomes boring." This is the failure mode of every linear superhero game. Pantheon solves it with five replayability engines that activate after story completion. These systems generate content forever, ensuring the game is never "done."

18.2 Engine 1: Daily & Weekly Challenges

- **Daily Hero Challenge** — Play 1 specific hero, complete 3 random crimes. Reward: 300-500 Credits. Refreshes every 24 hours.
- **Weekly Duo Challenge** — Specific hero pair, harder mission. Reward: 1000-1500 Credits + cosmetic. Refreshes every 7 days.
- **Weekly Assemble** — Co-op (or solo with AI), big reward. Refreshes every 7 days.
- **Hero of the Week** — One hero gets bonus XP all week. Encourages rotating the roster.

18.3 Engine 2: Suit Hunt (Collectathon)

50-80 suits total at launch, unlocked through story, missions, collectibles, challenges, and milestones. Hidden collectibles in the open world reward exploration. Specific challenge completions reward mastery. This is weeks of gameplay for a completionist, and every suit is a meaningful visual reward (cosmetic only, per Section 6).

18.4 Engine 3: Roguelike Mode — "Hollow Rifts"

Endgame mode. Portals open in the city. Enter one to access a procedurally generated dungeon with 10 floors. Pick a hero at entry. Every 3 floors, pick a buff (more speed, more damage, etc.). If you die, you lose the run. Boss at floor 10. Leaderboards track deepest runs. Hollow Rifts are the primary endgame content for solo players.

18.5 Engine 4: Endless Mode — "Patrol"

Free-roam the city with no mission tracker. Crimes spawn infinitely. See how long you last without going down. Score attack. Leaderboards. This is the "zen mode" for players who just want to swing/fly/run around the city and beat up bad guys indefinitely.

18.6 Engine 5: New Game+ (NG+)

After finishing the story, replay with: all suits unlocked from start, enemies scaled up, new dialogue and banter (heroes reference the playthrough), "Director's Cut" harder story missions. NG+ is for players who want to replay the story with all toys unlocked. NG+ completion is the true 100% marker.

18.7 Future: Living City (Live-Ops)

Post-launch (if the owner continues development), weekly villain events would have a specific villain take over part of the city for a week. Seasonal events (Halloween horror-themed crimes, Christmas snowy city) refresh the world. This requires ongoing content creation and is therefore optional for a personal project. The four replayability engines above are sufficient for endless play without live-ops.

18.8 Total Content Estimate

System	Lifespan
Story missions	~15 hours
Crime-in-Progress (procedural)	Infinite
Duo missions (7 designed)	~10 hours
Assemble missions	~5 hours + replayable
Suit hunt (50-80 suits)	~20 hours
Roguelike "Hollow Rifts"	Infinite
Daily/weekly challenges	Infinite
NG+	+15 hours
Total for completionist	60+ hours
Forever-content (post-completion)	Infinite

19. Phase Roadmap (0-4)

19.1 Phased Development

Pantheon is built in five phases. Each phase ends with a playable build that the owner can install on their phone and test. The vibe-coder workflow (play, report feel issues, AI tunes) operates continuously within each phase.

Phase	Scope	End State	Owner Playtime
Phase 0	Prototype: 1 hero, 1 district, 1 crime type	Velora in Midtown. Jog, sprint, wall-run, water-run, slow-time, lightning. Basic enemy. Bank robbery crime.	First playable. Proves the core feel.
Phase 1	3-Hero Switcher	Add Ironclad + Arachne. Hero-select menu. Each has unique movement + combat. Two more crime types.	Three distinct playstyles. Core loop proven.
Phase 2	Full Roster	All 10 heroes playable, each with unique kit. All 4 districts. All crime types. Vehicle emergencies.	Full game breadth. No story yet.
Phase 3	Content	Full campaign (25 missions). All 5 factions. All 10 bosses. HQ. Hero Phone. Suits. Progression.	Complete game. Story plays start to finish.
Phase 4	Advanced	Hero-swap mid-mission. Team-up combos. Destructible environment. Roguelike rifts. NG+.	Things Spider Fighter 3 doesn't have.

19.2 Phase Dependencies

Phases are strictly sequential — each builds on the previous. No skipping ahead. Phase 0 must feel right before Phase 1 begins (if the speedster doesn't feel good, the whole game is in trouble). Phase 1 must prove the hero-variety fantasy before committing to all 10 heroes in Phase 2. This staged approach prevents building content on a broken foundation.

20. Phase 0 Detailed Plan

20.1 Goal: Prove the Feel

Phase 0 has one job: prove that controlling Velora feels good. If sprinting through the city, running up walls, and slowing time to lightning-throw a thug is fun, the whole project is worth continuing. If it feels floaty, laggy, or unsatisfying, we stop and tune until it does. No new heroes, no story, no progression — just the core feel of one hero in one district.

20.2 Scope

Element	Included in Phase 0	Notes
Hero	Velora only	Jog, Sprint, Wall-Run, Water-Run, Slow Time, Throw Lightning
District	Midtown only	Small city block. ~10 buildings. 1 water feature for water-run test.
Crime Type	Bank robbery only	1 crime template. Spawns every 2 min.
Enemy Type	Street Thug (tier 1)	Idle → chase → attack AI. No ranged. No brutes.
Controls	Touch joystick + 5 buttons	Velora's button layout (Section 5.1).
UI	Minimal HUD	Health bar, mini-map, mission tracker. No phone UI yet.
Progression	None	All Velora abilities unlocked from start. No Credits. No suits.
Story	None	No cutscenes, no dialogue. Pure gameplay sandbox.
Suits	1 (Classic) only	No suit selector.
Save System	None	Refresh resets progress. Not needed for prototype.

20.3 Build Steps

- **Step 1: Project scaffold** — Next.js + R3F + Rapier + nipplejs. Deploy empty scene to Vercel.
- **Step 2: City block** — Procedurally place 10 buildings. Add water feature. Add ground plane. Basic PBR materials.
- **Step 3: Velora model** — Mixamo humanoid rig. Idle/run/jog animations. Third-person camera follow.
- **Step 4: Touch controls** — nipplejs left/right joysticks. 5 action buttons. Test input latency.
- **Step 5: Jog + Sprint** — Movement physics. Jog = walk speed. Sprint = super speed with motion blur.
- **Step 6: Wall-Run** — Collision detection on walls. Modified gravity while wall-running. Auto-disengage at corners.
- **Step 7: Water-Run** — Collision detection on water surface during sprint. Floatation Mode fallback.
- **Step 8: Slow Time** — Time-scale toggle. Velora unaffected. Visual filter (desaturation, vignette).

- **Step 9: Throw Lightning** — Aim with right stick. Projectile physics. Stun on hit.
- **Step 10: Enemy AI** — Street Thug. Spawn at bank. Idle until player approaches. Chase. Melee attack.
- **Step 11: Bank robbery crime** — Spawns every 2 min. Player defeats thugs. Crime resolves. Credits not awarded (no progression yet).
- **Step 12: Polish pass** — Tune speeds, camera distance, motion blur intensity, lightning range, enemy HP. Iterate based on feel.
- **Step 13: Deploy + install** — Push to Vercel. Owner installs PWA on phone. Plays. Reports feel issues.
- **Step 14: Tune loop** — Owner reports "X feels wrong." AI adjusts constants. Redeploy. Repeat until feel is right.

20.4 Success Criteria

Phase 0 is complete when the owner can install the PWA on their phone and answer "yes" to all of these questions:

- Does sprinting through Midtown feel exhilarating? (Motion blur, sound, world-blur all working)
- Does wall-running feel natural? (Auto-engages when I sprint at a wall, disengages when I stop)
- Does water-running feel like a flex? (Skim across the surface, slow-time to appreciate it)
- Does slow-time feel powerful? (Enemies crawl, I move normally, lightning throw is satisfying)
- Does the camera feel good? (Right distance, smooth follow, no clipping through walls)
- Are the touch controls responsive? (No lag on button presses, joystick feels precise)
- Is the frame rate acceptable? (No stutter during sprint, no drop during slow-time)

20.5 What Phase 0 Does NOT Include

- No other heroes (Ironclad, Arachne, etc. come in Phase 1).
- No other districts (Chinatown, Sand Town, Beach City come in Phase 2).
- No story, no cutscenes, no dialogue (Phase 3).
- No suits beyond the default (Phase 3).
- No progression system, no Credits, no upgrades (Phase 3).
- No vehicle emergencies (Phase 2).
- No bosses (Phase 3).
- No Hero Phone UI (Phase 3).
- No HQ / The Citadel (Phase 3).

21. Appendix: Hero Power Reference

21.1 Quick Reference Table

A condensed reference of every hero's power kit. For full details, see Section 5. This table is intended as a quick lookup during gameplay tuning.

Hero	Movement	Combat	Special	Buttons
Velora	Sprint, wall-run, water-run, air-run	Lightning throw, tornado	Slow time, walk through walls	5
Stormborn	Ride hammer (horizontal flight)	Hammer throw (horizontal), lightning strike	Storm call, thunder slam	4
Aegis Wing	Fly (mechanical wings)	Shield throw (ricochet), shield bash	Drone deploy, dive-bomb	4
Arachne	Web-swing, web-wing glide, wall-crawl	Web-shoot, web-yank	Web-zip, web-shield, spider-sense	4
Ironclad	Horizontal flight (vertical launch only)	Repulsor, unibeam, missiles	AI assist, mini-drones	5
Glitch	Hover-glider flight	Hack, drone swarm, EMP	Cloak (invisibility)	5
Pulsar	Vertical flight (Superman pose)	Photon blast, energy beam	Absorb, Binary Mode	4
Elasto	Flatten glide, slingshot	Stretch punch, shape-shift hand	Inflate body, multi-arm	4
Sentinel/Hollow	Flight (levitate)	Light blast / Hollow tendrils	Hollow Toggle (duality meter)	4
Mystic	Levitate (vertical flight)	Telekinesis, portal punch	Portal, time rewind, time stop	4

21.2 Boss Quick Reference

Boss	Counter-Hero	Key Mechanic
Kingmaker	Aegis Wing	Brute + summons. Ricochet shield to hit back weak point.
ZeroDay	Glitch	Hacks your controls. Counter-hack her.
Shadow-weaver	Mystic	Mirror dimension. Portal puzzles.
Eclipse	Pulsar	Energy absorption race. Out-pace her.
The Hollow	Sentinel	Duality phases. Light/dark form damageable.
Venomfang	Arachne	Symbiote. Camouflages. Spider-sense timing.
Crimson Dynamo	Ironclad	Armor duel. Weak points at joints.
Godspeed	Velora	Speed duel. Slow-time race + chase.
Trickster	Stormborn	Illusions + clones. Find the real one.
Titan-Killer	Elasto / Sentinel	Giant mech. Climb-on-body fight.

21.3 District Quick Reference

District	Theme	Hero Affinity
Midtown	Downtown skyscrapers	Ironclad, Arachne, Aegis Wing
Chinatown	Dense streets, neon	Arachne, Glitch, Mystic
Sand Town	Desert, scrapyards	Aegis Wing, Stormborn, Elasto
Beach City	Coastline, piers	Pulsar, Aegis Wing, Velora
Neon District (future)	Cyberpunk	Glitch
Mystic Quarter (future)	Floating temples	Mystic
Industrial Zone (future)	Factories	Elasto
North Ridge (future)	Snowy mountains	Event zone
Mirror Dimension (future)	Endgame	Mystic (then others)

21.4 Glossary

Term	Definition
Aegis Directive	The SHIELD-equivalent government agency coordinating hero activity.
The Citadel	The Pantheon HQ. A helicarrier.
Director Vance	Leader of Aegis Directive. Morally grey. Mid-campaign twist antagonist.
The Hollow	Cosmic entity sealed inside Sentinel. His dark alter-ego.
Godstone	Ancient artifact shattered into 5 fragments. Reunited = Hollow breaks free.
Duality Meter	Sentinel's resource. Fills as he uses abilities. At 100%, Hollow takes over.
Credits	In-game currency. Earned from missions. Spent on upgrades. No real-money purchase.
Hero Phone	Diegetic UI accessible mid-game. Mission alerts, suit selector, map, comms.
Assemble Mission	A mission where the player swaps between multiple heroes mid-mission.
Duo Mission	A mission requiring two specific heroes. Player controls one, AI controls the other.
Hollow Rift	Endgame roguelike mode. Procedurally generated 10-floor dungeons.
PWA	Progressive Web App. Installable web page that feels native. Pantheon's deployment format.
Vibe-Coder Workflow	Owner plays, reports feel issues in plain language, AI tunes constants, repeat.

Document Notes

This Game Design Document captures the design of Pantheon as discussed and agreed between the owner and the AI design lead across multiple design sessions. It is a living document — as the owner plays the Phase 0 prototype and provides feedback, this document will be updated to reflect design changes. The next step is to initialize the Three.js project scaffold and begin Phase 0 development.

All design decisions in this document exist to serve the player fantasy of controlling ten distinct superheroes in a living, breathing city. If a future feature does not serve that fantasy, it does not belong in Pantheon.